The multipolar moment and its contradictions

The emergence of BRICS+ and various other minilateral organisations can be attributed to the perceived shortcomings of the UN-led multilateral system. This development calls into question the effectiveness, relevance, and representativeness of existing international frameworks. However, this shift toward a multipolar world brings both promise and peril. On one hand, new formations like BRICS+ offer alternative platforms for countries of the Global South seeking more autonomy in global affairs. On the other hand, these platforms often operate in silos and lack the institutional strength of traditional multilateral systems.

Meanwhile, akin to the bipolar world of the Cold War era, the world is again witnessing two competing models of governance: the US-led market-driven framework versus China's state-led development model. Europe, caught between caution and dependency, leans toward the former while hedging risks. In between lies the Global South, a diverse set of nations navigating between these powers while scrambling to establish their own governance paths.

This fragmentation produces what scholars call epistemic dissonance, deep structural disagreements over policy as well as the fundamental nature of what governance should look like. The challenge is no longer just bias or underrepresentation; it's the imposition of a Eurocentric governance model, with systemic exclusion of diverse worldviews.

Towards a new model of global governance

The failures of current institutions go beyond exclusion. Many multilateral frameworks were created under the assumption of Western primacy and homogeneity. They do not reflect the plural, multilingual, culturally diverse realities of the 21st century.

A reimagined governance model for Africa must go beyond simply adding new voices to existing systems. It must recognise the continent's rich diversity, value indigenous knowledge, and respect the right of African nations to define their own development paths. Too often, Africa's complexity is ignored in externally imposed governance frameworks. What is needed is not a shift in dominance, but the creation of flexible, decentralised, and fair systems that distribute power more equitably and reflect the realities on the ground.

The 2023 accession of the AU to permanent membership of the G20 was a crucial breakthrough. Finally, Africa is represented as a bloc in the premier forum for economic cooperation, alongside the European Union (EU). This moment reflects a growing consensus that the continent can no longer be sidelined. It also coincides with more African nationals taking leadership positions in key global institutions, such as the World Trade Organisation (WTO), World Health Organisation (WHO) and most recently the UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO).

The G20 Leaders' Summit in November – the first on the African continent – will occur in the context of deep frustration over the continued exclusion of African perspectives. It is a historic opportunity to showcase African priorities: restructuring unsustainable debt, charting a way to reduce the climate finance gap for developing countries by 2035, and embedding the African Continental Free Trade Area in global trade frameworks.

From symbolism to substance

The world stands at a governance crossroads. Traditional institutions are losing relevance, while emerging powers are asserting themselves. In these changing realities, the future of global governance will not be decided by reform alone. It will be shaped by those who build new systems from the ground up — systems that are fairer, more inclusive, and better suited to the entire world, not just the interests of a few historically powerful countries.

Thankfully, South Africa's G20 offers that rare window of opportunity. Africa is more visible than ever in global governance, its demographic and economic importance are growing, and major powers, including the US, EU, China, Russia and Gulf States, are competing for its partnership. However, Africa must move beyond being a passive arena for global competition, as it was during the Cold War. Instead, it should use this renewed visibility to influence global norms and shape outcomes on its own terms. South Africa's G20 Presidency is a critical platform to champion this shift, from symbolic inclusion to meaningful influence in decision-making.



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